

Ivalin Ivanov

DevOps | CKA | 15+ years in IT | Ex-Siemens SysAdmin (USA)

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Professional Overview

Experienced IT professional now focused on DevOps and security. Certified Kubernetes Administrator (CKA) running a self-built, highly available Kubernetes (k3s) cluster: embedded etcd, Helm, Docker and containerd, Prometheus, Grafana and Loki, GitHub Actions multi-arch CI, Cloudflare Tunnel with SSO and Tailscale. Started as a Windows sysadmin at Siemens IT Solutions and Services in the US, then networking in Australia; since 2016 the sole technical person in a small-business IT company with 200+ customers. Trained through the SoftUni DevOps and Cloud program (Linux, Docker, Terraform, Ansible, CI/CD; module certificates 92–100%) and the KubeCraft Career Accelerator; CKS planned. Now building depth in AWS and Terraform.

Technical Skills

Container Orchestration: Kubernetes (k3s), embedded etcd HA, Helm, MetalLB, Traefik, NVIDIA device plugin, RBAC and NetworkPolicy (CKA)

Containers and CI/CD: Docker, containerd, buildx multi-arch builds (amd64 + arm64), GitHub Actions, GHCR, Gitea registry; Jenkins (training)

Infrastructure as Code: Terraform, Ansible

Cloud Platforms: AWS (in progress)

Linux and Scripting: Linux system administration (Ubuntu Server, Debian, Fedora, postmarketOS on ARM), systemd services, networking and troubleshooting, Bash, YAML

Monitoring: Prometheus, Alertmanager, Grafana, Loki, Uptime Kuma

Networking and Security: Cloudflare Tunnel and Access SSO (no open inbound ports), Tailscale VPN, SSH hardening with fail2ban, secrets management, network isolation for untrusted devices, Cisco routers

Homelab Projects

Self-Hosted HA Kubernetes Platform | bare-metal, always-on

Jan 2026 – present

Tech stack: k3s, embedded etcd, MetalLB, Traefik, Cloudflare Tunnel, Tailscale, Prometheus, Grafana, Loki, GitHub Actions

- 5-node k3s cluster: 2 x86 servers and 3 arm64 OnePlus phones on postmarketOS. 3-member etcd quorum using an etcd-only member; failover tested by stopping a server while the API stayed up. About 50 pods across 15 namespaces.
- No inbound ports: public services through Cloudflare Tunnel (2 replicas) behind Access SSO; administration over a Tailscale mesh with redundant subnet routers.
- Monitoring outside the failure domain: Prometheus, Alertmanager and Loki in-cluster, Grafana and Uptime Kuma on a separate host, alerts by SMTP, routing tuned to actionable alerts only.
- Profiled the control plane in production through the kubelet pprof proxy and found a leaked etcd goroutine; the upgrade cut k3s-server CPU from 104% to about 10%.
- Found a backup CronJob that had not completed once in 28 days; rebuilt it with dependencies baked into the image and added job-failure alerting.
- GitHub Actions builds multi-arch images to GHCR; every manifest kept in Git; incidents published as post-mortems. Built with heavy AI assistance (Claude Opus), every change verified on the hardware.

Self-Hosted Video Surveillance on Kubernetes | GPU inference, IoT containment

2026 – present

Tech stack: Frigate, Kubernetes, NVIDIA device plugin, TensorRT, MQTT, Cloudflare Access

- Frigate NVR on 6 IP cameras with TensorRT object detection on a GTX 1050 Ti. CPU and memory limits plus kubelet reservations ended repeated node lockups.
- Cameras have no route off the LAN; remote viewing only through SSO-gated Cloudflare Access.

GitHub: github.com/ivemcfire/homelab-config **Blog:** ivemcfire.github.io

Work Experience

Systems & Network Engineer | VivIdeas LTD, Bulgaria

2016 – present

- Sole technical person in a family-owned small-business IT company: 200+ customers and 200+ installations across offices, shops and homes.
- Server and PC support, network setup and on-site troubleshooting for small businesses.
- IP camera systems with local hosting on Blue Iris and Hikvision; next generation (Frigate on Kubernetes, ANNKE cameras, GPU detection) tested in the homelab.

- IT Support Technician** | [LowCost IT, Brisbane, Australia](#)

2010 – 2012
- Network setup and Cisco router configuration, hardware repairs and customer support.
- Windows System Administrator** | [Siemens IT Solutions and Services, Illinois, USA](#)

2007 – 2009
- Supported client sites Siemens Energy & Automation (Elk Grove) and KPMG (Schaumburg): Windows servers, Active Directory, Exchange mailboxes and backups.
 - On-call for after-hours incidents, including a Friday 9 PM server-room failure at a remote site affecting 500+ users.

Education & Certifications

- Bachelor's, Informatics and Computer Science** | [University of Economics – Varna, Bulgaria](#)

2004
- Certified Kubernetes Administrator (CKA)** | [The Linux Foundation](#)

2026
- DevOps and Cloud 2025** | [SoftUni, Bulgaria](#)

2025 – 2026
- Module certificates: Linux System Administration (92%), Containerization and Infrastructure with Docker, Terraform and Ansible (100%), CI/CD & Monitoring (99%). Kubernetes module certificate expected November 2026. Also took the Azure Essentials module.
- KubeCraft Career Accelerator** | [hands-on Kubernetes career program](#)

Mar 2026 – Mar 2027
- Homelab-first program. Following its content from January 2026 started my homelab; joined the program in March 2026.
- MCSE, MCSA, MCP** | [Microsoft, via NetXperts, Inc., Des Plaines, IL, USA](#)

2005 – 2006
- One-year program; also completed the Cisco CCNA course (no exam).

Additional Information

Languages: Bulgarian (native), English (fluent, professional use in the US and Australia)

Work authorization: EU citizen

Location: Targovishte, Bulgaria. Available for remote work